Names

Ruby names are used to refer to constants, variables, methods, classes, and modules. The first character of a name helps Ruby distinguish its intended use. Certain names, listed in the following table, are reserved words and should not be used as variable, method, class, or module names.

__ENCODING__		__FILE__	__LINE__	BEGIN	END	alias	and	begin
break	case	class	def	defined?	do	else	elsif	end
ensure	false	for	if	in	module	next	nil	not
or	redo	rescue	retry	return	self	super	then	true
undef	unless	until	when	while	yield			

Table 12—Reserved words

Method names are described later on page 465.

In these descriptions, *uppercase letter* means *A* through *Z*, and *digit* means *0* through *9*. *Lowercase letter* means the characters *a* through *z*, as well as the underscore (_). In addition, any non-7-bit characters that are valid in the current encoding are considered to be lowercase. Such names will not be usable from other source files with different encoding.

A *name* is an uppercase letter, a lowercase letter, or an underscore, followed by *name characters*: any combination of upper and lowercase letters, underscores, and digits.

A *local variable name* consists of a lowercase letter followed by name characters. It is conventional to use underscores rather than camelCase to write multiword names, but the interpreter does not enforce this.

```
fred  anObject  _x  three_two_one
```

If the source file encoding is UTF-8, ðelta and été are both valid local variable names.

An *instance variable name* starts with an "at" sign (@) followed by name characters. The general practice is to use a lowercase letter after the @. The @ sign forms part of the instance variable name.

```
@name  @_  @size
```

A *class variable name* starts with two "at" signs (@@) followed by name characters.

```
@@name  @@_  @@Size
```

A *constant name* starts with an uppercase letter followed by name characters. Class names and module names are constants and follow the constant naming conventions.

By convention, constant object references are normally spelled using uppercase letters and underscores throughout, while class and module names are MixedCase:

```
module Math
  ALMOST_PI = 22.0/7.0
end
class BigBlob
end
```

Global variables and some special system variables start with a dollar sign ($) followed by name characters. In addition, Ruby defines a set of two-character global variable names in